

“Whoever said a soggy spoon meant you lived a happier life?”

Portrait of a Jamstress

Miriam A. Brody

© 2026 Miriam Brody. All rights reserved.

This story, including all text, characters, plotlines, settings, and other original creative elements, is the intellectual property of the author. No part of this work may be copied, reproduced, republished, distributed, adapted, or used in any form without the author's prior written permission, except as permitted by applicable copyright law.

Unauthorized use, reproduction, or distribution of this work is prohibited.

By reading this story, you acknowledge that all rights to this work remain with the author.

Portrait of a Jamstress

Part 1: Brief history of the Plum Plume with a side of Lobster.

Chapter 1:

The scent of toasted hazelnuts and maple sugar floats from the white, teal, and marble counter-topped kitchen into the open living room, which is decorated with three reindeer taxidermy heads.

"Whatcha makin' honey?" Mr. Norkitch asks from his brown leather reading chair. He's reading *Bo Bedre* — Norway's home and garden magazine. The coffee grinder crackles. This time, putting the magazine down and turning around, "Coffee at this hour?"

From the kitchen, Elga says, "No, I'm not drinking it. She laughs, "It's for a new pudding recipe I'm trying. Oh, I'm also making those little hazelnut tartlets for the children's hospital bake sale."

Mr.Norkitch gets up from the couch and enters the kitchen, raising an eyebrow, "This is new. This pudding looks kinda different."

"Sissle made gelatin from the cow from her backyard—well, which used to be in her backyard. See, I can also get into this whole hunting and bones thing like you," Elga says flirtatiously, elbowing Mr.Norkitch.

The doorbell chime gently rings through the foyer. Mr.Norkitch and Elga look at each other and smile. At the same time, Barbell, their blind cookies and cream-colored terrier, gets up from his memory foam bed beside the fireplace and trots to the door to inspect the intruder. Who could it be at this hour? Then there's an insistent knock. Elga's fingers are covered in chocolate and hazelnut. She can't answer the door.

"Want to lick?" she asks Mr.Norkitch.

Laughing, Mr.Norkitch ties his brown bed jacket closed and walks towards their ornate ash wood Boreal forest door.

"WAIT," Elga runs her hands under the scalding hot water and barely wipes them dry on a washcloth. "You know I want to open the door with you. What if it's for me?" she says, sliding up to him.

"What if it's a murderer?" Mr.Norkitch asks in his attempt at an ominous voice.

"Well, that's even more the reason for me to open the door. I could roundhouse kick them and protect you," she says, reaching to place her hand on his shoulder, which is 173 cm high. He's 6'4. Elga is 5'4.

As Elga goes to open the door, Mr.Norkitch says, "I never knew a woman in the jam business would get so much mail and so many visitors that every time the door rings, she's accustomed to it being for her."

Elga crouches down to the floor. "Can you help me with this?"

Grabbing the left handle of the wicker basket, Mr.Norkitch asks, "Did you order this? What is—"

"—it's a summerween Boo Basket," Elga interrupts.

"Summerwee—"

"—Summerween, you know, Halloween but in the summer. It must be from Kathrine Rodriguez; she just moved down the street. She's from Crow Canyon, California."

They carry the basket and place it on the kitchen counter. Elga grabs the card from the top of the basket and tears the orange envelope that reads "You've BEEN BOOED!" open. The card has a ghost wearing a bikini, sunglasses, and a straw hat with a speech bubble that says "Guess Who" in comic sans.

Norkitches,

We loved the savory-sweet pumpkin spread. We made our favorite Colorados tamales and it paired perfectly. We hope you enjoy this little bout of 'summerween' themed treats to give you a taste of home and a few of our families' favorite chili flavors.

Elga, I can't believe my taco shop is opening in one week, so thank you for inviting me to the small business owners' women's luncheon. It was great to get to meet the community!

Love,

Guess who.

It's the Rodriguezes if you couldn't guess.

—Kathrine, Mark, Lina, and Diego

Holding out the card and pointing to the 'Norkitches,' "See, not all the gifts are for me; this gift-giving culture benefits the both of us."

"So this is a Boo Basket? What is being booed?" he asks.

"Okay, so you know Easter baskets? In the states—"

"—I love how you always say states like I didn't row for four years at Princeton."

"Well, Mr.Princeton, you don't know what a Boo Basket is, so clearly we need to expose you to more American culture. Anyways. As I was saying, a Boo Basket was born out of an Easter Basket. The Boo Basket is a tradition to surprise your neighbors or friends by secretly leaving a basket of treats on their doorstep. It's one of those things where one person does it. Then the whole block does it until everyone's pantries are filled with candied macadamia nuts, jars chock full of pretzels dipped in green with edible googly eyes attached to them, and the re-gifting drawer can't be further stuffed with artisan capers."

"As far as I know, it's July? Isn't Halloween in October?"

"Summerween is a thing, you know, to celebrate Halloween in the summer. Watermelon carving instead of pumpkins. But don't be fooled; it's in addition to Halloween, not a replacement."

"So I'm guessing we have to send something back."

"You're catching on."

Briskly sifting through the basket, she nods and says, "Impressive, Kathrine Rodriguez. Look, she remembered your love of bison meat and got that brand you like."

"This is really nice, but do you ever feel like this is kind of weird? A little over the top. All this neighborly gift-giving. There is so much packaging that's going to go into the oceans and get eaten by a turtle."

"Yeah, you know I do. But, you know, I kind of lead the women's small business groups here, and they do things like this. But you know what time it is now, it's tartlet time. They can't wait."

She gently places the basket in a closet near the living room, her movements graceful like a ballerina. After washing her hands, she unwraps a square block of 90% dark chocolate. She begins slicing through the 1-inch thick bar.

Smiling and taking a breath, Mr. Norkitch says, "Okay, sweetie, it's actually 20:30, so I'm going to bed." He kisses her on the cheek and then the lips. "C'mon, Barbell," he says, tapping his thigh. Barbell follows him.

When he is halfway up the stairs, Elga yells, "Love you!"

He yells back, "LOVE YOU too."

Chapter 2:

Elga is in the kitchen alone and working on the finishing touches of the chocolate glaze.

Elga in the kitchen every day as she has a culinary business of her own.

Elga calls it the Plume Plum Jam Store.

Only one type of jam is sold: each identical hexagonal glass jar is filled with jam from the same recipe and plum variety. After 11 years, her shop, her plum jam, is the most successful small business in the entire town. People travel across Scandinavia and across the world to visit Balestrand on the Coast of Norway to try fresh jam from her shop and grab a few jars to take home. Her shop also offers plain scones, clotted cream, and peppermint or black tea, but everything is focused around the main event—her plum jam. And each order comes with a paper napkin. The napkin has a printed doodle of plum, strawberry, orange, gooseberry, and raspberry. The napkins are her signature.

Before starting the Plume Plum, she spent two years finding the perfect recipe for jam. She wanted to make one type of jam perfectly. She spent the first six months deciding what fruit her jam would focus on. She was pretty sure it would be strawberries after visiting a farm in Nice. But, after staying at the 'La Strada Boutique Villa: Bed and Breakfast' in Argeş County, Romania, she found the perfect fruit. After having the richest forkful of plum pancakes, with urgency, asked the owner of the B&B where to find the plums. The orchard owner was excited to make a deal with Elga. Once the deal was set, Elga spent eight months sourcing ingredients and unique jars. Then she spent the next ten months perfecting the singular recipe and getting married to Mr.Norkitch, settling into her home in Balestrand, located on Norkitch family land, and securing a storefront on the main street in her town.

The smiles on her customers' faces made her heart sizzle with joy, and she loved the routine of making the same plum jam and teaching her shop bakers to make the same plum jam over and over.

A curiosity about how other fruits might go well with her perfect recipe started growing, but her desire to keep customers and the sales happy kept the lid on the curiosity. She really only worked on making the jam for her shop. That is, until her curiosity boiled over.

She was working on a slight tweak to her plum jam one night and ended up with leftovers in teal ceramic bowls. Earlier that day, Mr. Norkitch went to the market and bought all kinds of fruits and spices. She took them and mixed them up with the leftovers. Creating fantastical flavor concoctions—pickled peaches, honey-infused beetroot, lavender-mango marmalade. This started Elga's extravagant midnight cooking. Mr. Norkitch started calling it her Midnight Mischief.

Bing Bing Bing, the oven timer goes off. "Ohh, my tartlets." Elga licks the pudding off her fingers, grabs her salmon-shaped oven mitts, and pulls the hazelnut pastries out. She then places them on the cooling rack. While letting them cool in the mixing bowl, Elga combines the coffee, white chocolate, and raspberry syrup on the hob. Then, she combines unsweetened cashew milk, powdered gelatine, and a pinch of Himalayan sea salt. As the ingredients simmer gently on the stove, the sweet aroma of melted chocolate fills the kitchen. Stirring the mixture slowly, it thickens to a luxurious, satin-like texture. She pours it into eight single-serving crystal bowls to let it settle into a velvety pudding. Their glossy surfaces gleam against the diffused yellow light in the kitchen.

Chapter 3:

Elga goes upstairs to change out of her grey and white striped linen apron with ruffles around the neck strap and dresses in tan mulberry silk pajamas. She puts on her deerskin slippers. Mr. Nortkich loves hunting. But sustainable hunting. It's 21:00. She peers into the bedroom. Mr. Nortkitch is asleep. So is Barbell. She waltzes back down the hallway and stairs lined with hand-crafted crown molding. She hops onto the couch and snuggles under her white fluffy blanket. She scrolls on her phone, reading through WhatsApp app messages from the group chat "Sunday Tea Party Planning." She realizes she's sitting in the dark. "Hey Siri, turn on Elga's lamp." A warm yellow lantern turns on beside her. Feeling restless, waiting to see if the puddings are going to set properly, she sets down her phone and lets out a big sigh. She looks up at the ceiling and then stares at the reindeer head hanging across the room. Christmas lights are still wrapped around its neck. It's July.

She gets up and walks over to the craft closet. She's stopped by a grey fleecy cat that wraps its tail around her legs. "Hi," she says, lifting Soufflé into her arms. "How is my big, fluffy, handsome boy?" she says, twirling while hugging him. She places him on the kitchen island. She touches his nose with her finger and says, "You're right; we need some music. "Hey Siri, play Soufflé and Elga's Midnight Jams." Their favorite folk song starts playing. Opening the craft closet, she takes out red, white, and yellow ribbons and her purple scissors, which have golden stars speckled all over them.

The speakers fill the room with the twang of the banjo and the lyrics "I walked for years, passed the grass, but something always brought me back to you, you, you."

Soufflé follows Elga dancing into the kitchen and to the cupboard beside the sink. This is not a last-minute decision to clean dishes. Elga keeps the dish liquid on the left shelf. This is the jam cabinet. This is where she keeps all the flavors she does not sell in her shop. There is a shelf

for each fruit type: plum, strawberry, orange, gooseberry, and raspberry. She takes a moment to meditate on which flavor to wrap up as a thank-you gift for Sissle. Clementine-vanilla-star anise marmalade or gooseberry custard? Both are too generic.

"Well, Sissle makes fresh goat cheese like every week, so—. Ugh, I don't know. Wait, definitely smoky fig and black pepper. That'll pair nicely," she says to herself. With a satisfied smile, she cuts a silky piece of yellow ribbon and ties a bow around the glass jar. Holding up the jar, with a relieved sigh, Elga says, "I do love the way a jar of jam looks when I know the things mixed together would make the average person cringe."

"Jingle Bells, Jingle Bells," her phone goes off. Mr. Norkitch loves Christmas music but dislikes the sound of notifications because he believes life cannot be well lived by constantly being bombarded with notifications. So, Elga set her phone notifications to be Christmas themed. It's another text from the "Sunday Tea Party Planning."

Sunday Tea Parties started between Tina, Perri, Lucinda, and Elga because all their husbands, led by Mr. Norkitch, go clay pigeon shooting each Sunday. The girls decided to all come together, have tea, talk, and trade expertise. Tina teaches the group to croquet. Perri teaches them new yoga moves. Lucinda leads the coastal trail runs. Elga, of course, brings jam. But not the sugary stuff she sells in her shop. She brings a different superfood jam (or at least jam adjacent substance) each week. Last week, she made dark-cherry collagen compote, and the week before, açai and chia seed pudding. For the girls, only things that will help them glow. Not to say her plum jam doesn't make them shine, but Elga does not think it's good to eat the same jam or thing constantly. Elga goes out of her way to try extraordinary foods with the same tenacity Mr. Norkitch organizes his sock drawer.

"Oh my goodness, Soufflé! I have been texting back and forth with Tina for 45 minutes," Elga says, picking herself up from leaning on the kitchen island. She stretches her back by touching her toes and then bringing her arms over her head like she is about to dive into a pool. Soufflé is curled up in a ball on the couch. Elga tiptoes over to him and puts her face into his fuzzy belly with plans to pick him up and hop into the bed upstairs.

"(Christmas) The church bells in town, (Christmas) All ringing in song, (Christmas) Full of happy sounds, (Christmas) Baby, please come home." Elga's phone goes off from a text notification from her cousin Sandra. She is still on the couch. She fell asleep on the couch. She opens the notification to find it's a photo sent to the family group chat called "We love sunsets and salty hair." A marbled countertop with a blue and white china plate decorated with blue daisies sits a rectangular cake frosted with vanilla buttercream, decorated with red and blue frosting ruffles, and garnished with strawberries that are cut and arranged to look like a lobster. Sandra captioned it with "#Bringing dessert to a summer party. HAPPY FOURTH OF JULY EVERYONE. Can't wait to see the kiddos try their first Lobster this summer at the annual Norringtonmay lobster bake." She puts down her phone, and when she sees it fall into the couch cushion, she ignores it.

She walks to the coat closet to grab her teal and pink fluffy robe. Entering the kitchen with sleepy eyes and a yawn, still half asleep, "Oh, hi."

"Good morning," Mr.Norkitch says, pouring green juice from a pink SMEG-branded blender into two glasses.

Slumping onto a kitchen island stool, Elga says, "How was your run."

"2 miles repeats, with a 7-minute split", he replies, smiling still on his runner's high and handing her a glass of juice with a pink and white striped straw.

"I like the new orange shorts and the pink headband," Elga says, looking him up and down and sipping on the kiwi and kale mixture.

"Well, you know, in this foggy weather, gotta stay visible," he responds.

Mr. Norkitch takes a seat beside her. He's eating avocado toast with a side of tinned salmon, and reading the Sunday paper—the physical version. Elga looks out the window at the neighbor's red barn. A black and white sheepdog runs out, and behind the dog runs two kids wearing yellow rain boots and raincoats. They splash in the puddles.

"The forecast is for rain for the whole week. The whole week," Elga says.

"We could go on that green moss hike you've been wanting to go on, it's perfect weather for that. I'm sure you could snap some great photos," Mr. Norkitch says, turning to the paper's sports section and then taking a crunch out of his breakfast.

"How hard do you think it would be to do an outdoor lobster bake this afternoon?" she asks, looking at the kids pouring muddy water on the dog.

Mr. Norkitch responds, "Well, given that we don't have sand, no bonfires are allowed, and it's raining. Quite hard." Looking at his Apple watch, he says, "What day is it? Oh, it's the fourth of July. Well, if you are craving Lobster, we could drive to that lobster place in Ålesund. I'm pretty sure they're open today."

"No, no, it's okay," Elga says, laughing a little. She gets up and wraps her arms around him from behind. Rocking side to side, she says, "Wanna try my cow bone pudding."

"Oh, I would love to," Mr. Norkitch responds. "But, you see, I just had such a BIG breakfast; I'm SO full, I couldn't possibly eat more," he says, rubbing his abs and laughing.

"You got out of Sissel's cow bones this time, but next time, you might not be so lucky," she says, walking over to the sink with the empty juice glasses.

Crash. One of the glasses falls and shatters into the sink.

"Ugh, you know what, I'm not okay. Can we go to Ålesund?" she turns around and asks.

Chapter 4:

After taking Elga two hours to get ready, they are in the green Land Rover on the 38-minute drive to the lobster shop in Ålesund.

Elga is sitting in the passenger seat, looking out as they pass by mountain goats. "Oh my goodness," Elga says, covering her mouth. "I am supposed to be at Perri's right now." She forgot about Sunday Tea Time. She has not missed it for 108 weeks, besides vacations. "Well, I guess my streak is broken. I'm texting Lucinda to pick up the goji berry honey pots so they can eat those up and not go to waste. Wait OMG! You forgot about clay pigeon shooting, too."

Mr. Norkitch smiles, "I already texted them."

"Of course you did."

Sitting outside the lobster shop in Ålesund, they eat at the picnic table looking over the coast. Once they finish eating, Elga watches her husband throw away their wrappers.

"Happy Fourth of July," Mr. Norkitch says as he walks back to the bench.

"I'm trying my best to do the happy part of Fourth of July, but it's hard seeing all the photos from home," Elga responds, looking out at the water.

Checking his watch, in an effort to cheer Elga up, "It's about to start raining again in 15 minutes. You love summer rain."

"Yeah, it's just different when paired with an evening sunset at the beach later that day, you know. And I'm guessing there won't be a fancy sunset tonight. I know being nostalgic is bad because it never shows the full truth, but today, when I saw Sandra's cake, I don't know, it made me want to go visit home. This is so weird because we go every Christmas, and that's been enough for the past years. I never even liked the Fourth of July *that* much. Maybe I just miss the people." She turns to Mr.Norkitch. "You know I love my customers, but there's never the comfort of Mildas with their Mosaic Nights coming by the store. I just so often get Mr. Crisp Linen Pants, soon-to-be jammy pants, and his dull 'are we there yet' type of kid coming by."

"Mildas?" Mr. Norkitch asks. He does not question the Mr. Crisp Linen Pants because he knows exactly the type she is referring to.

"Sometimes I wonder if being so radical about only selling plum jam is, I don't know. Sometimes, in the shower, I fantasize about selling smoked fig bacon jam on little rosemary crisp crackers." A long pause of silence. "I was thinking in August of maybe starting to give free samples."

Absolutely in shock, Mr.Norkitch stands up and says, "That's Great!!!!!! Oh, my goodness. Finally! I have been waiting until Midnight Mischief could reach its full potential." However, a tear trickles down Elga's face. It feels like a defeat of the plan to stay Plume Plum strong till the end of time.

You see, Elga Norrringtonmay grew up in the Hamptons in a house painted a soft shade of rose, with a porch shaded by sprawling hydrangeas. Her parents ran a lobster shop on High Street, so Elga spent her summers helping out at the shop. She observed the creatures who paraded by—like the local cat who always examined the dog water bowl with a solemnity that

suggested more wisdom than most of the tourists who wandered in with sugar highs and stories from their snow cone breakfasts. Milda, who would always order something along the lines of "For the lob, please add half n half to my usual salad; actually, can you put two salads and add the pineapple ranch and Long Island dressings? It's Mosaic Night at the club." She was always up to something artistic. Elga's favorite was when Milda used shells and lobster claws to make a sculpture and then asked Elga's parents if they would put it up in the shop for a couple of weeks.

Some people look like they would be a Lob Shop customer: yellow shirt, teal and pink-striped board shorts, Tommy Bahama hat, golden retriever parked on the bike rack. They come into the shop, buzzing with some mumbling noises as they review the menu, but before Elga can ask them what they want to order, they say, "Thanks so much, have a nice day," which always actually comes out as "Thanks so much—" because the wind slams the door biting the second half of the sentence off. Only leaving the sound of the silver doorbell ringing. If one of the non-customers exits the Lob Shop around 7:45 PM, when the sun paints the pink and orange sky, this would not be the last time Elga would see them that evening. The Lob Shop was situated along the water beside the collection of sandalwood benches and trash cans. So, there was a clear view of the beach from behind the counter. At around 8:05 PM, the same non-customer would be visible from behind the counter at the Lob Shop.

Mr. Yellow Ralph Lauren Polo stained with an oval grease mark, not made better by the slight protrusion of a beer belly, throwing away brown paper wrappings—his, the wife's, the kid's—wait, he notices there is one more piece, so he quickly plops it into his mouth—oh no now he's got tartar sauce on the collar as well. What did he spend \$42 on? Gourmet soda? Well, yes, he's gotta make the kid quiet somehow. But the rest he spent on Lobster. Not Lobster from the Lob Shop, no, no, no. From the Place Around the Corner. They also sell Lobster. They also have

the title of best lobster place in all the tourist magazines. And yes, that is what it's called—' Place Around the Corner.' The same tourist magazines list the Lob Shop at #2 and always push the comment "wanna give your tongue a fishy flavour journey this is the place!"

Most teenagers were busy, infuriated by the frustration of blackheads accumulating on their noses. Elga's frustration was that it was much more enticing to say, "I am going to grab us some grub from The Place Around The Corner," rather than, "Hey kids, let's go to Lob Shop."

They had one job but fumbled with the name, probably many other things, and ended up second. Her parents spent their lives building a business that had the potential to be the best, being on the High Street, with such a lovely view and all, but ended up falling short. Elga was kept up at night thinking about what would happen if she grew up to be like her parents: always second best.

Much like the products of her parent's shop, Elga was a woman of the sea. She loved swimming since before she could walk. At 15, she was an all-star water polo player, bringing home national titles. At every regional match, Mom would invite the team to the ice cream shop Every Flavorite. Elga's usual order was picking something different every time. 38 different flavors with a 1 ½ scoop where three flavors could be mixed means 54,872 combinations. No combination possibility could be wasted. A memorable combo was bubble gum, raisin bran, and caramel cheesecake crunch.

On a comfortable afternoon sometime in August, nearing her 16th birthday, she watched Mr. Salmon Quarter Zip attempting to deal with the butter on his khakis with a pink sky as the backdrop. Returning to sifting through *Town and Country Dogs Edition* magazine "Place Around the Corner... Pff. It should be called 'Guaranteed Stain From Down The Street.'"

"Sorry, I didn't catch that."

Elga didn't realize she'd said that out loud. A customer had walked into the shop.

"Hi, sorry, how are you? What can I get you?"

The new customer glanced at the extensive menu board above the teal counter, which listed all seventeen items the Lob Shop offered. "Umm, sorry, I need a moment... But you have a lovely shop. The teal is stunning."

"My dad minored in art in college; he loves color theory."

The customer hesitated, still scanning the menu. "Sorry, I don't want to get the wrong thing. There are so many options." They followed it with a forced laugh. "Umm, thank you so much." The customer left the shop. The silver doorbell rang.

That was not the only bell that went off. A bell ticked off in Elga's head. Same Stain. Same brown wrappers. Two items to order on the menu. All facets of the Place Around The Corner. The problem with her parents' show was that they tried to do it all with an extensive, varied menu. They should have picked one thing, like the lob salad, and perfected it.

Walking around her house that night, she saw how the three carpets in the living room didn't match. She noticed the vases in the foyer: one Art Deco, one Ikea, and one hideously painted at an overpriced ceramics place. Nothing matched. Worst of all, her room was just the same. She was already turning into her parents.

She swore it all off. She would never be on a wild goose chase like her parents, trying to do everything, but she would pick one thing to do well. She would have routines. She would have a *usual*. She would know something well. She would not be second best. She would stick to a plan. Radically, she applied this everywhere in life.

Never again did she step into Every Flavorite. Craving ice cream? She went to The Lemon Spool and always ordered vanilla. A helpful way to understand what kind of place The Lemon Spool is is to compare their spoons to Every Favorites' spoons. After paying at Every Flavorite, to the left of the counter is a wall with a colored bin for every color of the rainbow. In each bin is a colored metal spoon. As each reusable spoon has been carefully engraved with a positive message such as "have a sunny day," Every Flavorite has a cursive scripted sign that asks that the metal spoons be returned. At The Lemon Spool, they puncture the cream by sticking in a mini compostable spoon. It's more minimalistic. But also, after a few minutes, tends to get quite soggy.

She made a plan to stick with vanilla. She was going to do everything to try to be strict with herself to do one thing well.

"The best laid schemes o' Mice an' Men,
Gang aft agley,
An' lea'e us nought but grief an' pain,
For promis'd joy!"
—Robert Burns.

The first night in Norway, Elga wrote a poem in her journal:

now, in Norway,
the sky is grey,
now married to Mr. Norkitch,
no longer Norringtonmay.

The evening of Fourth of July, 2025 she wrote a new poem:

now, in Norway,

the sky is grey,

now married to Mr. Norkitch,

no longer Norringtonmay by name.

But find infinite flavors, and you'll know who to blame.

Despite my laments.

I am who I am.

I am proud to be me, even if that means making jam with ham.

Note for readers: End of Chapter 4. Rest to be continued.